wind was blowing, that he actually switched on the news. Even then, his first preference was for a channel that was showing the UP results.

With every result from UP, Shah felt an increasing sense of relief. He had been predicting as many as sixty seats for the BJP from the state, but the trends showed that the party was set to even cross that mark. His only disappointment was that his friend Jaitley had lost. His first port of call after the numbers were out was to Jaitley's house. It was the one dampener to what had been a spectacular performance.

I asked Shah how he felt to be projected as the Man of the Match. *'Rajdeepji, yeh meri jeet nahi hai, yeh har karyakarta ki jeet hai!'* (This is not my win, it is the victory of each worker). Had he anticipated such a big win, I asked. *'Sach kahen toh hamein bhi anuman nahi tha ki itni badi jeet hogi. Yeh toh vakai mein ek tsunami hi hai!* (Even we did not anticipate the scale of this win, this is truly a tsunami)', he said, with a smile that was getting bigger by the minute.

We finished our news coverage at around 11 p.m. After a long, gruelling day in the studio, I was ready for an Old Monk with coke. But one more call remained to be made. I telephoned Modi's residence in Gandhinagar to congratulate him. The operator who picked up the phone said Modiji was in a meeting and would call back. At midnight, I tried my luck one last time. The operator was apologetic. *'Sorry, Saheb sowa chali gaya'* (Saheb has gone to sleep).

The boy from Vadnagar with the blazing eyes and burning ambition was going to be the prime minister of India. An RSS swayamsevak was to take over as the country's chief executive. Long years in politics, the determined building of a massive personality cult in the face of the hard rock of controversy, had resulted in this extraordinary achievement. Narendra Modi deserved a good night's rest.